

What Is GEO? A Business Owner's Guide to Generative Engine Optimization

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Search stopped being a list of blue links. It became an answer. GEO is how you make sure the answer includes you.

The way people find businesses has quietly changed. A few years ago, a prospect typed a query into Google, scanned ten blue links, and clicked. Today, a growing share of those prospects never see the links at all. They ask ChatGPT, Perplexity, or Google's AI Overviews a question and receive a single synthesized answer — one that names a handful of companies and ignores everyone else.

Generative Engine Optimization, or GEO, is the discipline of making sure your business is one of the companies that gets named. If SEO was about ranking, GEO is about being cited.

Why Traditional SEO Is No Longer Enough

SEO was built for a world of ranked results. You optimized a page, earned some links, and competed for position on a page of ten options. The user did the final work of choosing.

AI search collapses that model. When someone asks Perplexity for "the best commercial HVAC company in Austin," the engine doesn't hand back a page to browse. It returns an answer — often two or three named businesses with a short justification for each. As of early 2026, Google AI Overviews appear on well over half of informational searches, and roughly 60% of Google sessions now end without a click to any external site. The traffic that used to flow from position three or four has largely evaporated.

This is the uncomfortable part for operators: you can rank on page one of traditional Google and still be invisible to the AI layer sitting on top of it. Ranking and being cited are now two different games. GEO is the second game.

How AI Search Engines Decide What to Surface

AI engines don't "rank" in the classic sense. They retrieve, reason, and synthesize. When a model builds an answer, it pulls from a mix of its training data, a live retrieval layer (real-time web results), and

a set of trust signals that tell it which sources are safe to cite.

The practical implication is that these engines are looking for businesses they can confidently name without being wrong. They favor entities they recognize, sources that are consistent across the web, and content that directly and clearly answers the question being asked. Ambiguity is the enemy. A business that shows up under three different names, with inconsistent addresses and thin, marketing-heavy pages, is a business the model quietly leaves out — not out of malice, but out of caution.

The Retrieval Layer vs. The Training Layer

It helps to separate two things. The training layer is what the model already "knows" from its last training cut. The retrieval layer is what it fetches live when it needs current information. GEO works on both: you want to be established enough that models recognize you from training, and clearly structured enough that live retrieval can extract and cite you accurately.

The 5 Core GEO Signals

Across platforms, five signals do most of the heavy lifting.

- 1. Entity authority.** Does the AI recognize your business as a distinct, real-world entity — not just a URL? Businesses with a defined identity across the web (consistent name, verified profiles, a knowledge graph presence) get cited far more often.
- 2. Structured data.** Schema markup tells engines exactly what your business is, what it does, and where it operates. It removes guesswork, and AI engines reward the removal of guesswork.
- 3. Citation velocity.** How often, and how recently, credible third-party sources mention your business by name. This is the modern successor to backlinks — mentions matter even without a link.
- 4. Review signals.** Volume, recency, and sentiment of reviews across platforms. AI engines treat consistent, current review activity as evidence of a live, trustworthy operation.
- 5. Content freshness and clarity.** Content that answers real questions plainly, is updated regularly, and is written to be extracted — not just skimmed.

Practical First Steps

You don't need a full overhaul on day one. Start here.

First, audit your entity consistency. Search your business name across Google, your profiles, and directories. Fix every mismatch in name, address, and phone. This is unglamorous and it matters more than almost anything else.

Second, add or clean up your structured data. At minimum, implement Organization and, if you serve a location, LocalBusiness schema. Add FAQ schema to pages that answer common questions.

Third, test what the engines already say about you. Ask ChatGPT, Perplexity, and Gemini directly: "What do you know about [your business]?" and "Who are the best [your category] in [your market]?" The gap between what they say and what you'd want them to say is your GEO roadmap.

This is the work we do at [Hey Pearl through our GEO service](/services/geo) — building the authority infrastructure that makes a business legible to the machines now doing the recommending.

Frequently Asked Questions

Is GEO just a rebrand of SEO?

No. They share DNA, but the objective is different. SEO optimizes for ranking in a list of links. GEO optimizes for being retrieved, trusted, and cited inside an AI-generated answer where there is no list to scroll.

Do I need to abandon my SEO work?

Not at all. Strong SEO fundamentals — fast, crawlable, well-structured pages — remain the foundation. GEO builds on top of them. Think of it as adding a second layer, not replacing the first.

How long does GEO take to show results?

Entity and structured-data improvements can influence AI answers within weeks, because retrieval is live. Deeper shifts — citation velocity and training-layer recognition — build over months. GEO is compounding, not instant.

Which AI engine matters most for my business?

It depends on your audience, but you shouldn't optimize for just one. The underlying signals — entity clarity, structured data, citations, reviews — help you across ChatGPT, Perplexity, Gemini, and AI Overviews simultaneously.

Can I do GEO myself?

The first steps, yes. Entity cleanup and basic schema are within reach for most operators. The harder work — sustained citation building, knowledge graph establishment, and cross-platform consistency at scale — is where most businesses bring in help.

How do I know if GEO is working?

You measure it the way the engines see you: track how often you're named in AI answers for your key queries, monitor your citation footprint, and watch for referral traffic from AI platforms, which now appears distinctly in analytics.